# CORPORATE SUSTAINABILITY & GOVERNANCE PRACTICES

*Comparative Analysis Report*

## Financial Year 2019–20

***Sectors Covered: Power • Banking • FMCG • Steel • Technology • Engineering • Ports***

# Executive Summary

This report presents a comparative analysis of corporate sustainability, governance, and human capital practices across twelve major Indian corporations for the financial year 2019–20. The analysis is drawn from a structured review of Annual Reports and Sustainability Reports published by Reliance Power, Bank of Baroda, ITC, JSW Steel, Tata Steel, Wipro, Escorts, Adani Enterprises, Adani Ports & SEZ, and Adani Power, covering more than 675 individual disclosures across 18 thematic areas.

Across the dataset, Governance & Code of Conduct emerged as the most universally disclosed topic, with 11 of 12 companies providing substantive coverage reflecting the mandatory reporting requirements under SEBI Listing Obligations. Health and Education followed closely, each covered by 10–11 companies, demonstrating the centrality of social investment and CSR to corporate reporting in India. Climate Action and Environmental Sustainability were addressed by 10 and 6 companies respectively, signaling growing awareness of environmental responsibility, though with notable variation in depth.

On the human capital front, Employee Wellbeing and Whistleblower Policy were the most widely reported HR topics (8 companies each), while Talent Management and Employee Value disclosures were comparatively sparse. ITC, Tata Steel, JSW Steel, and Wipro demonstrated the most comprehensive and structured HR disclosures. The Adani Group companies were strong on environmental and social sustainability themes.

Financially, ITC reported the highest absolute net profit at ₹15,136 crores with a CSR spend of ₹307 crores (approximately 2.03% of net profit). Tata Steel and JSW Steel each invested over ₹150 crores in CSR activities. Reliance Power and Adani Power reported net losses and therefore had no mandatory CSR obligations. Wipro's CSR spend as a share of net profit was the most substantial among profitable companies.

## Key Findings at a Glance

- Governance & Code of Conduct: highest disclosure coverage (11/12 companies)
- ITC leads in breadth of sustainability reporting across employees, environment and social themes
- Adani Group companies show strong environmental and CSR community programs
- Tata Steel and JSW Steel are the most detailed on safety, wellbeing and diversity
- Employee Talent Management and Product Sustainability remain under-reported areas
- CSR spending ranges from ₹9 crores (Adani Enterprises) to ₹307 crores (ITC)

# Company Profiles

The following profiles summarize the key disclosures and standout practices identified for each company in the dataset.

## Reliance Power

Reliance Power is a power generation company with a diverse portfolio. In FY2019-20, the company reported a net loss of approximately ₹389 crores, limiting its mandatory CSR obligations. Reliance Power's disclosures centered on environmental stewardship — specifically its commitment to Zero Liquid Discharge at all power plants and mines, certified Integrated Management Systems for Environment, Occupational Health & Safety, and Quality. On human capital, the company highlighted employee development as a strategic differentiator, with emphasis on continuous learning and career progression. Women's empowerment through Self-Help Groups (SHGs) featuring 600+ members was a notable CSR highlight.

**Strongest Themes:** *Environmental compliance, Employee learning, Women empowerment via SHGs*

## Bank of Baroda

Bank of Baroda, one of India's largest public sector banks, demonstrated strong governance and learning & development disclosures. The bank's comprehensive "Baroda Gurukul" learning management system — featuring e-learning, Baroda Tube, gamified learning ("Baroda Bahubali"), and the "UTSUK" onboarding program — stands out as a best practice. The bank also documented robust green initiatives including paperless approvals, bio-gas plants, solar installations, and energy-efficient LED lighting. Corporate governance philosophy is anchored in transparency, accountability, and stakeholder fairness.

**Strongest Themes:** *Learning & Development (Baroda Gurukul), Green banking initiatives, Corporate governance*

## ITC Limited

ITC delivered the most comprehensive sustainability reporting in the dataset. With a net profit of ₹15,136 crores and CSR spend of ₹307 crores (~2.03%), ITC's disclosures spanned the full breadth of ESG themes. Key highlights include: the "WOW – Well-Being Out of Waste" program (78,800+ tons of dry waste managed); water stewardship achieving five times net water consumption in rainwater harvesting; 81,510 youth covered under skill development programs aligned to PMKVY; and the iEngage Employee Engagement Survey achieving 95% employee pride scores — among the highest globally. ITC's corporate governance philosophy is rooted in trusteeship, transparency, and ethical citizenship.

**Strongest Themes:** *Waste management, Water stewardship, Skill development, Employee engagement, Governance*

## JSW Steel

JSW Steel presented strong HR and sustainability disclosures. The company's talent management framework includes partnerships with Ivy League institutions and IIMs for leadership development. JSW Springboard (gender diversity flagship), JSW SAMVEDNA (mental wellness), and JSW WE CARE (employee assistance) reflect a holistic approach to people. The JSW Learning Academy serves as an online education portal. On environmental sustainability, JSW Steel operates under a "VISION 000" zero-harm safety target and has implemented extensive water management systems with zero liquid discharge. CSR spend of ₹152 crores reached communities across 255 villages in four states.

**Strongest Themes:** *Talent management, Gender diversity, Safety culture (VISION 000), Water management*

## Tata Steel

Tata Steel's disclosures reflect a mature, structured approach to sustainability governance. The company's MOSAIC Diversity & Inclusion framework covers gender, PWDs, LGBTQ+, and other community groups. Safety governance is driven by an Apex Safety Council and Safety Excellence Journey committee. The company achieved 100% solid waste utilization at Jamshedpur and Kalinganagar facilities — an industry benchmark. Tata Steel Medical Services established 1,200 beds for COVID-19 response, and the Tata Steel Foundation extended food and livelihood support to communities in Jharkhand and Odisha. CSR spend of ₹193 crores was among the highest in the sample.

**Strongest Themes:** *D&I (MOSAIC), Zero waste achievement, Safety governance, Community healthcare*

## Wipro

Wipro's sustainability governance is notable for its multi-layered structure — from Board-level oversight to the Chief Sustainability Officer — and its benchmark-driven reporting approach. With 100,000+ employees under ISO 14001 and OHSAS certifications, health and safety coverage is extensive. Waste management achieved 81% recycling rate (excluding C&D debris), while water efficiency improvement targets of 5% year-on-year were in place. The Ombuds process and Code of Business Conduct underpin governance. CSR spend of ₹181.8 crores (in millions) represented a meaningful commitment relative to net profit.

**Strongest Themes:** *Sustainability governance structure, Waste management, Water conservation, Code of conduct*

## Escorts Limited

Escorts demonstrated emerging sustainability practices with room for improvement in reporting clarity — several sustainability report entries in the dataset showed OCR-quality issues suggesting early-stage digital reporting maturity. Key highlights include the Escorts Care Accelerate Program (ECAP) for managerial capability development, role-based training replacing grade-based schedules, and an e-portal (eCub) for employee engagement. Environmentally, Escorts has implemented energy conservation measures across plants and offices and monitors water recycling at its EAM manufacturing facilities. CSR spend of ₹9.85 crores was modest relative to its ₹471.7 crores profit.

**Strongest Themes:** *ECAP capability development, Energy conservation initiatives, Environmental compliance*

## Adani Enterprises

Adani Enterprises disclosed a strong governance and water infrastructure narrative, particularly through its PPP projects under the National Mission for Clean Ganga. The company's sustainability governance mechanism spans Board of Directors down to site-level Sustainability Reporting Committees. With corporate governance philosophy centred on Courage, Trust and Commitment, and CSR spend of ₹9 crores against ₹699 crores profit, Adani Enterprises is positioned to scale its social investment. The company's ASDC (skills training centre) uses 3D printing and augmented-reality-based simulators for vocational training.

**Strongest Themes:** *Water infrastructure (Clean Ganga), Sustainability governance structure, Skills training (ASDC)*

## Adani Ports & SEZ

Adani Ports & SEZ (APSEZ) provided rich disclosures across environmental and social sustainability themes. Highlights include mangrove afforestation covering 2,889 hectares; electrification of port operations with ₹47 crores invested in FY20 for renewable energy transition; green cover of 745 hectares across all ports; and a comprehensive waste management vision of "Zero Waste to Landfill." The Adani Foundation's work in Kutch (75 borewells recharged, 54 rooftop rainwater harvesting structures, 22 check dams) and Vizmart (women SHG market outlet) exemplify targeted community development. CSR spend of ₹70 crores was the second highest in the sample by absolute value.

**Strongest Themes:** *Mangrove conservation, Port electrification, Water harvesting, Women empowerment (Vizmart)*

## Adani Power

Adani Power reported a net loss of ₹1,341 crores in FY2019-20, limiting CSR obligations. Despite this, the company-maintained disclosure across governance, environmental, and social themes. The High Concentration Slurry Disposal (HCSD) system for fly ash management at Tiroda, and an internal water consumption target of 2.5 $m^3$/MWh (below the regulatory limit of 3.5 $m^3$/MWh), demonstrate operational sustainability focus. Adani Foundation's mobile healthcare units, Adani Aarogya Card health insurance (covering 9,483 community members), and 39 health camps in Tiroda reflect robust community health programs.

**Strongest Themes:** *Fly ash management, Water efficiency, Community healthcare (Adani Aarogya Card)*

# Thematic Analysis

## Human Capital & Workforce Management

Human capital disclosures varied significantly across the sample, with some companies providing structured frameworks while others offered only statutory information.

### Talent Management & Learning

JSW Steel, Tata Steel, and Wipro stand out for systematic talent management. JSW Steel's partnership with Brown, Cornell, ISB, IIM-A, IIM-B and XLRI for Individual Development Plans, alongside its JSW Learning Academy digital platform, represents best practice. Wipro's development-focused performance management system with quarterly feedback cycles and annual 360-degree reviews is similarly structured. Bank of Baroda's Baroda Gurukul system — encompassing e-learning, gamified learning and a dedicated onboarding program is a standout in the banking sector.

Escorts' ECAP (Escorts Care Accelerate Program) covering 280 participants across Platinum-to-Silver certification tiers, and ITC's Developmental Planning System focused on equal opportunity, add breadth to the sector picture. Reliance Power and the Adani Group companies disclosed relatively less on formal talent pipelines.

### Diversity & Inclusion

Tata Steel's MOSAIC framework — covering Gender, PWDs, LGBTQ+, and diverse community groups is the most comprehensive D&I disclosure in the dataset. JSW Steel's Springboard program for high-performing women employees and JSW Shakti (rural women entrepreneurs, registered as a Section 8 company) reflect multi-dimensional inclusion efforts.

ITC's equal opportunity policy explicitly prohibits discrimination across caste, religion, disability, gender, sexual orientation, race and marital status. In FY2019-20, ITC employed 2,973 female employees out of 28,115 total and 69 differently abled employees. Adani Ports' Vizmart (14 shops run by women SHGs in Kerala) and Adani Foundation's women training programs in Kutch represent community-level women empowerment.

### Employee Wellbeing & Safety

Eight of twelve companies disclosed substantive wellbeing programs. JSW Steel's SAMVEDNA (mental wellness workshops) and WE CARE (employee assistance program) represent leading practice in psychological wellbeing a theme absent from most other company disclosures. ITC's wellbeing framework covers preventive health checks, group accident insurance, maternity leave, elder care support, and sports/recreational activities at all units. Tata Steel's COVID-19 "pod concept" — self-sufficient groups deployed at manufacturing and raw material locations — and Wipro's thermal screening and social distancing protocols reflected proactive pandemic management.

On occupational safety, Tata Steel's Apex Safety Council governance structure and JSW Steel's VISION 000 (Zero Harm) motto demonstrate top-down safety commitment. ITC's Safety by Design and Safety by Culture dual-pillar strategy resulted in 17,031 person-days of EHS training in FY2019-20.

### Whistleblower & Sexual Harassment Policies

Whistleblower disclosure was one of the most uniformly reported topics, with 8 companies providing substantive coverage — largely driven by statutory requirements under Section 177 of the Companies Act. Tata Steel's Vigil Mechanism is the most comprehensive, encompassing a Whistleblower Policy for Directors & Employees, Business Associates, Anti-Bribery, Anti-Corruption, Anti-Money Laundering, and Conflict of Interest policies.

On Prevention of Sexual Harassment, 7 companies reported compliance with the POSH Act 2013. Tata Steel reported 34 complaints received (26 resolved, 8 under investigation) — the highest absolute disclosure, suggesting a more mature reporting culture. Reliance Power, Adani Enterprises, Adani Ports, and Adani Power all reported zero complaints during the year.

# Environmental Analysis

### Solid Waste Management

Nine companies disclosed waste management practices. Tata Steel achieved 100% solid waste utilization at its Jamshedpur and Kalinganagar facilities and created the Tata Aggreto and Tata Nirman brands for LD slag repurposed as road construction aggregates. ITC's WOW (Well-Being Out of Waste) programme managed 78,800+ tonnes of dry waste in FY2019-20, covering 786 wards and creating sustainable livelihoods for 16,200 waste collectors.

Adani Ports' Zero Waste to Landfill vision achieved an 18% reduction in hazardous and non-hazardous waste in FY20. Wipro's 81% recycling rate (excluding C&D debris) and near-100% e-waste recycling through approved vendors reflects strong operational waste management. JSW Steel's waste management in 12 surrounding villages (4 tons wet + 1 ton dry waste collected daily) demonstrates community-level impact.

### Water Management

Water stewardship was reported by 8 companies. ITC's water stewardship approach targets 40% specific water consumption reduction from 2014-15 and rainwater harvesting potential equivalent to over five times its net water consumption. Working across 2.09 lakh acres of farmland with micro-irrigation achieving 20-45% water savings, ITC's water programme is the most comprehensive in the sample.

JSW Steel's six RO plants recover 19,000 $m^3$/day of makeup water and reuse 45,000 $m^3$/day of treated water, maintaining zero liquid discharge. Adani Ports recycles 1.5 million litres per day (targeting 10 million litres by FY25) and constructed 22 check dams and 54 rooftop rainwater harvesting structures. Adani Power maintains an internal water consumption target of 2.5 $m^3$/MWh — well below the regulatory limit of 3.5 $m^3$/MWh.

### Climate Action & Energy

Ten companies addressed climate action in some form, though depth varied considerably. Tata Steel's Centre of Excellence on Climate Change, exploring hydrogen as fuel and carbon capture technologies, represents the most advanced climate strategy. Adani Ports' electrification of port operations and ₹47 crore renewable energy investment in FY20 marks a concrete transition pathway. ITC addressed climate through energy efficiency, renewable energy portfolio expansion, and green building integration.

Escorts documented an extensive list of energy conservation measures across its plants, including VRF-based HVAC systems, VFD compressors, and a 58.32 KW solar plant. Bank of Baroda's Green Banking Initiatives Hybrid UPS systems, solar panels, and bio-gas plants at its corporate office — represent sector-appropriate climate action.

## Governance & Ethics

Governance was the best-reported theme across all 12 companies, consistent with mandatory regulatory requirements. ITC's governance philosophy — anchored on trusteeship, transparency, ethical corporate citizenship, empowerment & accountability and control — is the most elaborately documented, with its Code of Conduct derived from three fundamental principles: good corporate governance, good corporate citizenship, and exemplary personal conduct.

Bank of Baroda's governance principles focus on shareholder value maximization, ethical and transparent dealings, and timely disclosures. The Adani Group's Courage-Trust-Commitment governance tenet is consistently cited across Adani Enterprises, Adani Ports, and Adani Power, reflecting a group-level governance framework. Wipro's four-layer governance structure (Shareholders → Board → Sub-Committees → Management Process) with an Ombuds process is notable for its structural clarity.

## Social Sustainability & CSR

Social sustainability was covered by 9 companies. JSW Steel's CSR reached communities across 255 villages in four states with a ₹152 crore spend, covering health (1.2 lakh patients annually), maternal care (29,500 pregnant women tracked), cataract surgeries (8,200 facilitated), and adolescent girls' health (22,000 sensitised). ITC's Swasthya Choupal programme — using 430 rural women as micro-health entrepreneurs reaching 3.04 lakh women — exemplifies innovative CSR delivery models.

Education disclosures were provided by 10 companies. ITC's PMKVY-aligned skills programme enrolled 14,014 youth in FY19-20 (44% female, 34% SC/ST) with 73% placement rates. Adani's ASDC (using augmented reality for vocational training) trained 55,000 people across ten states in its first 3.5 years. Wipro's community health partnerships span five states addressing maternal health, nutrition, and preventive care.

# Financial vs CSR Analysis

This section analyses the relationship between corporate profitability and CSR expenditure for the 10 companies for which financial data was available in FY2019-20. All figures are standardised to ₹ Crores.

| Company | Net Profit / (Loss) ₹ Cr | CSR Expenditure ₹ Cr | CSR as % of Net Profit |
|---|---|---|---|
| **Reliance Power** | -388.84 | N/A (Loss) | N/A |
| **Bank of Baroda** | 5,468 | N/A | N/A |
| **ITC** | 15,136 | 307.00 | 2.03% |
| **JSW Steel** | 5,291 | 152.00 | 2.87% |
| **Tata Steel** | 6,744 | 193.00 | 2.86% |
| **Wipro** | 8,681 | 181.80 | 2.09% |
| **Escorts** | 472 | 9.85 | 2.09% |
| **Adani Enterprises** | 699 | 9.00 | 1.29% |
| **Adani Ports** | 1,934 | 70.00 | 3.62% |
| **Adani Power** | -1,341 | N/A (Loss) | N/A |

## Key Observations

- ITC reported the highest absolute net profit (₹15,136 Cr) and highest absolute CSR spend (₹307 Cr), though at 2.03% of net profit it was not the highest CSR intensity company.
- Adani Ports achieved the highest CSR intensity at 3.62% of net profit (₹70 Cr on ₹1,934 Cr profit), reflecting strong community investment relative to profitability.
- JSW Steel (2.87%) and Tata Steel (2.86%) both exceeded the statutory 2% CSR threshold, demonstrating a genuine commitment beyond minimum compliance.
- Escorts and Wipro each allocated 2.09% to CSR — marginally above the statutory 2% minimum representing baseline compliance rather than discretionary social investment.
- Adani Enterprises allocated only 1.29% of net profit to CSR (₹9 Cr on ₹699 Cr profit), the lowest intensity among profitable companies in the sample.
- Bank of Baroda did not report CSR spend figures in its Annual Report for this period, consistent with regulatory transition dynamics post-amalgamation.
- Reliance Power and Adani Power reported net losses and therefore had no mandatory CSR obligations under Section 135 of the Companies Act 2013.

# Interactive Coverage Matrix

The table below maps each company against the 16 core sustainability and governance themes, indicating where substantive disclosures were identified (✓) versus not found (–).

| Company | Employee Value | Talent Mgmt | L&D | Diversity | Engagement | Whistleblower | POSH | Wellbeing | Env.Sustain | Solid Waste | Water Mgmt | Governance | Social CSR | Health | Education | Climate |
|---|---|---|---|---|---|---|---|---|---|---|---|---|---|---|---|---|
| Reliance Power | ✓ | – | – | ✓ | – | ✓ | ✓ | ✓ | ✓ | ✓ | – | ✓ | – | – | – | – |
| Bank of Baroda | – | – | ✓ | – | – | – | – | ✓ | – | – | – | ✓ | ✓ | – | – | ✓ |
| ITC | ✓ | – | ✓ | ✓ | ✓ | ✓ | – | ✓ | ✓ | ✓ | ✓ | ✓ | ✓ | ✓ | ✓ | ✓ |
| JSW Steel | – | ✓ | ✓ | ✓ | ✓ | ✓ | – | ✓ | – | ✓ | ✓ | ✓ | ✓ | ✓ | ✓ | ✓ |
| Tata Steel | – | ✓ | – | ✓ | – | ✓ | ✓ | ✓ | ✓ | ✓ | – | ✓ | ✓ | ✓ | ✓ | ✓ |
| Wipro | – | ✓ | – | – | – | ✓ | ✓ | ✓ | – | ✓ | ✓ | ✓ | ✓ | ✓ | ✓ | ✓ |
| Escorts | – | – | ✓ | – | ✓ | – | ✓ | – | ✓ | ✓ | ✓ | ✓ | ✓ | – | ✓ | ✓ |
| Adani Enterprises | – | – | – | – | – | – | ✓ | – | – | – | ✓ | ✓ | – | ✓ | ✓ | ✓ |
| Adani Ports | – | – | ✓ | ✓ | – | ✓ | ✓ | – | ✓ | ✓ | ✓ | ✓ | ✓ | ✓ | ✓ | ✓ |
| Adani Power | – | – | – | – | – | ✓ | ✓ | ✓ | – | ✓ | ✓ | ✓ | ✓ | ✓ | – | – |

# Key Observations & Gaps

## Leaders in Sustainability Reporting

ITC demonstrated the most comprehensive reporting, with substantive disclosures across 14 of the 16 themes analysed. The quality and depth of ITC's sustainability report — covering environmental stewardship, employee wellbeing, community development, and governance — sets a benchmark for Indian corporate reporting. Tata Steel and JSW Steel were the next strongest performers, each covering 12–13 themes with structured, quantified disclosures. Adani Ports & SEZ showed notable breadth across environmental and social themes.

## Under-Reported Areas

- Employee Value & Talent Management: Only 1-3 companies provided substantive disclosures on people as strategic assets and formal talent pipeline management. This is a significant gap given the talent-intensive nature of many businesses in the sample.
- Product Sustainability: Covered by only 5 companies, this is underreported relative to its importance for consumer and manufacturing companies. JSW Steel and ITC had the most structured product sustainability disclosures.
- Life Below Water & Biodiversity: Despite Adani Ports' extensive marine operations, detailed water ecosystem disclosures were limited. Only Adani Ports provided mangrove-related disclosures.
- Supply Chain Sustainability: Tata Steel's Responsible Supply Chain Policy was the only explicit supply chain sustainability disclosure in the dataset — a significant gap for companies with complex supplier networks.

## Reporting Quality Observations

- Escorts Sustainability Report contained OCR-quality text issues (garbled characters, run-on words), suggesting the report was digitised from a physical document with limited post-processing. This reduces comparability and accessibility of Escorts' disclosures.
- Bank of Baroda, as a recently amalgamated entity, did not report full CSR spend data — an area to watch in subsequent reports as the combined bank's operations stabilise.
- Adani Group companies show a consistent governance narrative (Courage, Trust, Commitment) across all three entities (AEL, APSEZ, APL), reflecting group-level policy harmonisation — a strength for consolidated stakeholder communication.
- Reliance Power and Adani Power, both reporting net losses, had understandably thinner HR and social disclosures, consistent with financial constraints on voluntary CSR activities.

## Sector-Specific Patterns

Steel companies (JSW Steel, Tata Steel) showed the strongest safety and environmental disclosures — appropriate for high-hazard industrial operations. The IT/technology sector (Wipro) showed strength in governance structure and waste management but had limited community health disclosures relative to FMCG (ITC) or steel peers. Banking (Bank of Baroda) demonstrated distinctive strengths in learning & development and green banking but had thinner direct community impact disclosures. Power sector companies were notably focused on environmental compliance (water, waste) and safety certifications.

# Conclusion

This comparative analysis of sustainability, governance, and human capital disclosures across twelve major Indian corporations for FY2019-20 reveals a landscape of meaningful progress alongside notable gaps. The mandatory requirements of the Companies Act 2013 (CSR spending, POSH compliance, Whistleblower policy) have successfully driven baseline disclosures across most companies. However, the quality, depth, and strategic integration of sustainability reporting vary considerably.

The leading reporters — ITC, Tata Steel, JSW Steel, and Wipro — have moved beyond compliance to frame sustainability as a core business imperative with quantified targets, multi-year programs, and stakeholder-level disclosures. Their reports demonstrate that sustainability disclosure and business performance are complementary, not competing, objectives.

The primary recommendations arising from this analysis are: (1) standardize talent management and employee value disclosures as a human capital reporting minimum; (2) expand product sustainability reporting, particularly for manufacturing companies; (3) improve supply chain sustainability visibility; and (4) invest in the digital quality of sustainability reports to enable comparable, machine-readable data — as evidenced by the challenges with Escorts' digitized report.

As India's SEBI Business Responsibility and Sustainability Report (BRSR) framework becomes mandatory for the top 1,000 listed companies from FY2022-23, the companies in this sample — many of which are BSE/NSE-listed — will face higher standardization requirements. This analysis provides a useful baseline for tracking progress under that framework.

*— End of Report —*